January 2001, an estimated sixty million people participated—the largest human gathering in history.

Xuan Zang tells us that large numbers of people participated in the festival in the seventh century including the rulers of different countries and even Buddhists. Most interestingly, he describes the rituals of the sadhus (ascetics). Evidently, a large wooden column was erected in the middle of the river and the sadhus would climb it. At sunset they would hang from the column with one leg and one arm while stretching out the other leg and arm into the air. Thus would they stare into the setting sun. The wooden pole and the particular ritual are no longer around, but, considering the ash-covered sadhus who still congregate at the Kumbh Mela, the ritual seems entirely in character.[20]

Despite these outward signs of continuity, one does get the feeling that the economic and cultural centre of gravity steadily shifted to the south. Even militarily, the southern kings could more than hold their own against the kingdoms of the Gangetic plains. When Xuan Zang visited India, the northern plains had been welded into an empire under Emperor Harsha, but he was roundly defeated by the Chalukya king Pulaksen II when he attempted to extend his empire into the Deccan.

The source of southern power was trade—both with the flourishing Indianized kingdoms of South East Asia as well as with the Persians and Arabs who had replaced the Romans in the west. The kingdoms of the south were aware of the importance of commerce and actively encouraged it. When necessary, they were not afraid to use military might to keep the trade routes open. The most famous examples of this are the Chola naval expeditions to South-East Asia in the eleventh century.

The Cholas were an ancient dynasty and are even mentioned in Ashokan edicts. In the ninth to the eleventh century AD, they created an empire that covered most of peninsular India and briefly extended to the banks of the Ganga. Unusually for an Indian empire, however, it also had a maritime empire that included Sri Lanka and the Maldives. For the most part, they also had very good relations with kingdoms of South-East Asia. Inscriptions on both sides show the existence of large merchant communities and that